



Ambubhai Patel, an Agaria and the only graduate in a community of nearly 30,000 that subsists only on salt farming: "The Agarias are a monument to exploitation."

It's a vicious cycle. The earning period for an Agaria in the Little Rann starts soon after monsoon when he takes an advance payment or loan from a wholesale salt trader after fixing the price at which he has to sell his produce to the trader at the end of the season. This is when the tragic cycle of exploitation starts. The advance money is towards his running cost as well as cost of crude oil that he uses to operate the pump to draw saline water from ground. Even the land he lives on at his

**That some human beings still live in such primitive, almost medieval, conditions is quite unbelievable in this day and age, as is the exploitation by middlemen.**

salt pan is part of a cooperative society controlled by a trader. Since the work lasts seven months, the Agarias bring their families with them. The family first constructs a makeshift hut and then the entire family hardens the land and raises embankments with its bare hands and feet to create seven to 11 pans, most measuring around 50 ft by 50 ft. Simultaneously, they dig a well and begin drawing saline groundwater

and pump it into the first of the salt pans. The saline water is then transferred from one pan to another through canals to increase its salt content till it reaches the final pan where it starts producing salt.

The primitive nature of their existence can be gauged from the fact that when an Agaria wants to convey a message to another family located at a distance of say one to two km, he uses a